

Today, one doesn't even require a Hotmail account to sign on to MSN. An MSN Passport service account is all that's required and you can use MSN Messenger with the e-mail id you registered on Passport.

The chat window has lots of features such as the usual smileys, winks, display pictures, themes for the chat window, and more. Font sizes and colours can be easily modified. On the whole, it gives the user a lot of options in terms of appearance, which is one of the crucial factors in such software.

On the security side, Microsoft has covered a lot since critical flaws were found in version 6.5. Thankfully, no major security flaw has been found in version 7.0 till date, for which some credit should go to Microsoft for maintaining most of the ActiveX features and fixing up the flaws.

The overall chatting experience on MSN is pleasant and there aren't any bugs or features that may be a bother. The webcam feature is good, and picture quality on a broadband connection is fairly good. It works OK even over a 56K modem.

A feature that has been missing from MSN Messenger is offline messaging. If a user is offline, you cannot leave a message that can be checked the next time they log in.

Overall, MSN Messenger is one of the best chat clients—simple to use, with all the necessary features.

